Learning Through Listening

Manasi Tata Kirloskar has focused on building trust, and to be open to seeking help when required

BY **KARAN DHAR**



MANASI TATA KIRLOSKAR

Vice Chairperson, Toyota Kirloskar Motor; Executive Director, Kirloskar System Pvt Ltd

BEST MANAGEMENT ADVICE RECEIVED

One piece of advice that has stayed with me throughout my career is to not allow your ego to make decisions. Over time, I have learned that the best outcomes come from listening, staying open to different perspectives, and focusing on what is right for the organisation

WHEN MANASI TATA Kirloskar stepped into the role of Vice Chairperson of Toyota Kirloskar Motor in January 2023, she did so at a moment she had not anticipated. Her father, Vikram Kirloskar, passed away suddenly, pushing her to take on responsibilities earlier than planned.

"The most important lesson is to be prepared for the unexpected. The sudden passing of my father was both a deeply personal loss and a significant turning point, as I had to assume greater responsibilities much earlier than I had anticipated," Kirloskar, Vice Chairperson of Toyota Kirloskar Motor and Executive Director of Kirloskar System Pvt Ltd, tells *BT*.

"The challenge was the immediacy of the position at a very unexpected time. The entire ecosystem was used to working with my father, who built the company from the ground up and created strong relationships with everyone," she says. "The transition required me to accelerate my learning much faster than I had expected."

That's when Kirloskar decided to focus first on building trust and learning, and to be open to seeking help when required. "The experience has shaped my approach to leadership and has taught me to remain adaptable, stay grounded during periods of change and view challenges as opportunities to learn and evolve," she says.

Cut to 2026, Toyota Kirloskar Motor has become India's fifth-largest carmaker by volume, accounting for around 7% share in the country's highly competitive passenger vehicle market.

Leadership, according to Kirloskar, is about creating long-term value not just for businesses, but also for people, communities and society at large.

One thing that Kirloskar consciously unlearned was the notion that leaders always need to be at the forefront of every decision or every conversation. "Over time, I have come to appreciate that effective leadership is often about enabling others, creating trust and allowing people with the right expertise to step forward. I have learned that leadership is more about being a catalyst for collective success, creating an environment where individuals and teams can perform at their best," she says. BT

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